



AROUND 80 PERCENT OF MY FOCUS GOES INTO REFINING MY EXISTING SKILLS, AND 20 PERCENT INTO DEVELOPING A NEW VARIATION

Varun Chakaravathy may appear calm on the field, but his mind rarely rests. “I think about how to improve 24x7,” he says, admitting it can be “irritating” for those close to him. But that’s just how he’s wired — constantly consumed by the game.

Over the last few months, the leg-spinner has been on a remarkable run. A key figure in India’s Champions Trophy triumph, Varun emerged as the team’s second-highest wicket-taker in the tournament with nine wickets, thriving in the heat of Dubai. Yet, the 32-year-old isn’t getting carried away. “I want to see where I stand in seven months,” he says, his focus already shifting to what lies ahead.

Speaking from Kolkata Knight Riders’ team hotel, Varun reflects on his unusual path — one marked by late entry, multiple injuries, and a dramatic reinvention.

“My goal wasn’t a comeback. I just wanted to be more impactful,” he says, referring to the change in bowling action that revived his career in 2021.

An architect by qualification and a cinema buff by passion, Varun’s

journey feels almost scripted. From school-level wicketkeeper to medium-pacer, from quitting a corporate job to becoming a spinner due to a knee injury — his story defies the norm.

Spotted in the Tamil Nadu Premier League, he rose swiftly, only to hit a rough patch three years ago. But he bounced back. With IPL in full swing, Varun remains grounded, chasing consistency and believing firmly that his “peak is yet to come.”

The last few months have been a roller-coaster for you. If you could take us through your journey and how confident were you coming into the IPL?

Yes, the last few months have been significant for me in cricketing terms, as I had the opportunity to play for the country and contribute to the Champions Trophy victory. And now that the IPL has started, I’m feeling good about the team and about myself.

In IPL, where wickets are different from one venue to another, how do you prepare?

At Eden Gardens, the conditions usually favour batters. That’s always

Wrecker-in-chief: Varun

Chakaravathy led India’s bowling in its Champions Trophy win, claiming nine wickets in three innings at an impressive average of 15.11. REUTERS

at the back of my mind, so I prepare accordingly. Whenever I get the ball during practice, I make sure to train with that in focus.

I also set specific challenges for myself with certain batters in the nets. That helps me stay sharp.

Our head coach, Chandu sir (Chandrakant Pandit), and Bravo (Dwayne) have been very supportive of what I do.

You’ve been with KKR for a while now and are one of the senior bowlers. What kind of conversations do you have within the bowling group?

At Eden Gardens, the boundaries are smaller than most other grounds in India, so that’s always on our minds. We plan carefully, especially if there’s a longer side—we focus on how to bowl into that area.

The Powerplay is particularly challenging here. There are certain lengths you need to hit to get the